

Adaptive Oscillating Ascent

A Framework for Navigating Change in Motion

Always moving UP



Never moving down

Executive Summary

Most frameworks treat transformation as a straight line. They are wrong, and those who rely on them pay for it.

The Adaptive Oscillating Ascent (AOA) Framework presents a fundamentally different account of change: one in which change is not linear but oscillatory, not static but adaptive, and not aimless but directional. The lateral movement, the pendulum swing between perspective and adaptation, is not a detour from progress. It is the engine of it.

AOA is built on three foundational principles. Perspective must evolve for change to begin. Perception gives that change its angle and direction. The climb is not waiting at the end of the process. It is already taking place within it.

This paper introduces the AOA Framework, traces its conceptual grounding, and demonstrates its application across personal transformation, organizational change, and leadership development. It is written for the navigator who is ready for a more honest account of how transformation actually moves.

The Problem: Why Straight-Line Thinking Fails

For decades, transformation has been taught as a straight line. The stages are predictable: from awareness to adoption, from resistance to commitment, from current state to future state. Follow the steps and you will arrive.

The lived experience of change tells a different story.

Anyone who has moved through genuine transformation knows this firsthand. The path is never straight. Progress oscillates. Perspectives shift. Ground that felt solid gives way. What looks like deviation is often the ascent itself.

The reason most change initiatives fail is not that people resist change. It is that they are holding a map that does not match the terrain.

Three failures follow from this assumption. Each one corresponds to a pillar of the framework.

Perspective Is Treated as Fixed

Straight-line models assume the destination is clear, the map is reliable, and the navigator simply needs to execute. What they consistently fail to account for: the terrain shifts while the navigator is still moving through it. A perspective that was accurate at the start may be insufficient halfway through. Perspective must evolve continuously or the map becomes a liability.

Direction Gets Lost

When perspective shifts but perception does not engage, movement continues without angle. The navigator sees the environment differently but cannot determine how to move within it. The result is energy without vector: motion that produces activity but not ascent. A shift in perspective that is not met with perceptual direction is a change that goes nowhere.

The Climb Gets Missed

When arrival becomes the only valid measure of progress, the journey is reduced to overhead: something to be compressed, managed, and survived. Lateral movement gets flagged as wasted motion. The oscillation that is actually producing the ascent gets treated as deviation. What is missed is the central truth the framework is built on: the climb is not waiting at the end. It is taking place within the movement itself. People and organizations arrive at destinations unprepared, because neither the journey nor the oscillation was understood as formative.

The AOA Framework: What It Is

Adaptive Oscillating Ascent is a framework for understanding how meaningful change actually moves: not in a straight line, but in a continuous upward oscillation that is simultaneously lateral and directional.

The most effective navigators share a common pattern. They do not travel in straight lines. They oscillate. They shift perspective. They adapt continuously to their environment. And through that oscillation, they ascend. The lateral movement is not incidental to their progress. It is the source of it.

The name carries the three essential properties of the framework.

Adaptive

The navigator responds continuously to what the environment is actually doing. The path is not fixed in advance. The movement is intelligent, not mechanical. Adaptation is not a contingency plan. It is the primary mode of operation.

Oscillating

Movement is lateral as well as forward. The left swing and the right swing are not deviations from the path. They are the structural motion of genuine ascent. Remove them and the ascent stops.

Ascent

The direction is fixed and non-negotiable. Whatever the lateral oscillation, the overall trajectory is always upward. The framework has one direction built into it: up.

The Central Claim

AOA makes one central claim, and it is both precise and consequential: the oscillation is not the cost of ascent. It is the mechanism of it.

Remove the oscillation and you do not get a faster ascent. You get no ascent at all.

The Three Pillars

AOA is structured around three foundational principles, and none stands alone.

Pillar One: Perspective

"Perspective is always evolving. Perspective has to change or change will never take place."

Transformation does not start with action. It starts with sight. Perspective is the governing frame that determines what is noticed, what is treated as threat, and what movement becomes possible. Capable people get stuck not from lack of effort, but because their perspective has not yet evolved to meet what the next level requires.

Pillar Two: Perception

"Perception is the key because without perception, change has no angle or direction."

If perspective governs how reality is seen, perception governs how movement is directed. Perception gives change its angle. It turns awareness into directional intelligence. Without it, even an evolved perspective remains incomplete. Perception reads signals, detects meaning, and converts each shift into deliberate calibration.

Pillar Three: The Climb

"In the journey is the climb."

The third pillar establishes the central truth of the framework: ascent is not separate from the process. It is embedded within it. The climb is not waiting at the end of the journey. It is taking place within the movement itself.

This is what separates AOA from straight-line models of progress. In linear thinking, lateral movement looks like delay. In AOA, it may be the very mechanism by which upward progress occurs. The path appears to swing, but it never descends. What looks like nonlinearity is often the signature of genuine ascent.

The climb is not after the journey. The climb is in it.

Perspective allows the frame to change. Perception gives that change direction. The climb reveals that true ascent is already taking place within the adaptive movement itself. The motion shifts, but it does not collapse.

The path oscillates, but it keeps rising. The journey shifts, but the direction holds.

The Visual Model

The AOA Framework is expressed as a visual model because the diagram communicates what language alone cannot: the relationship between oscillation and ascent, rendered as a single integrated image.

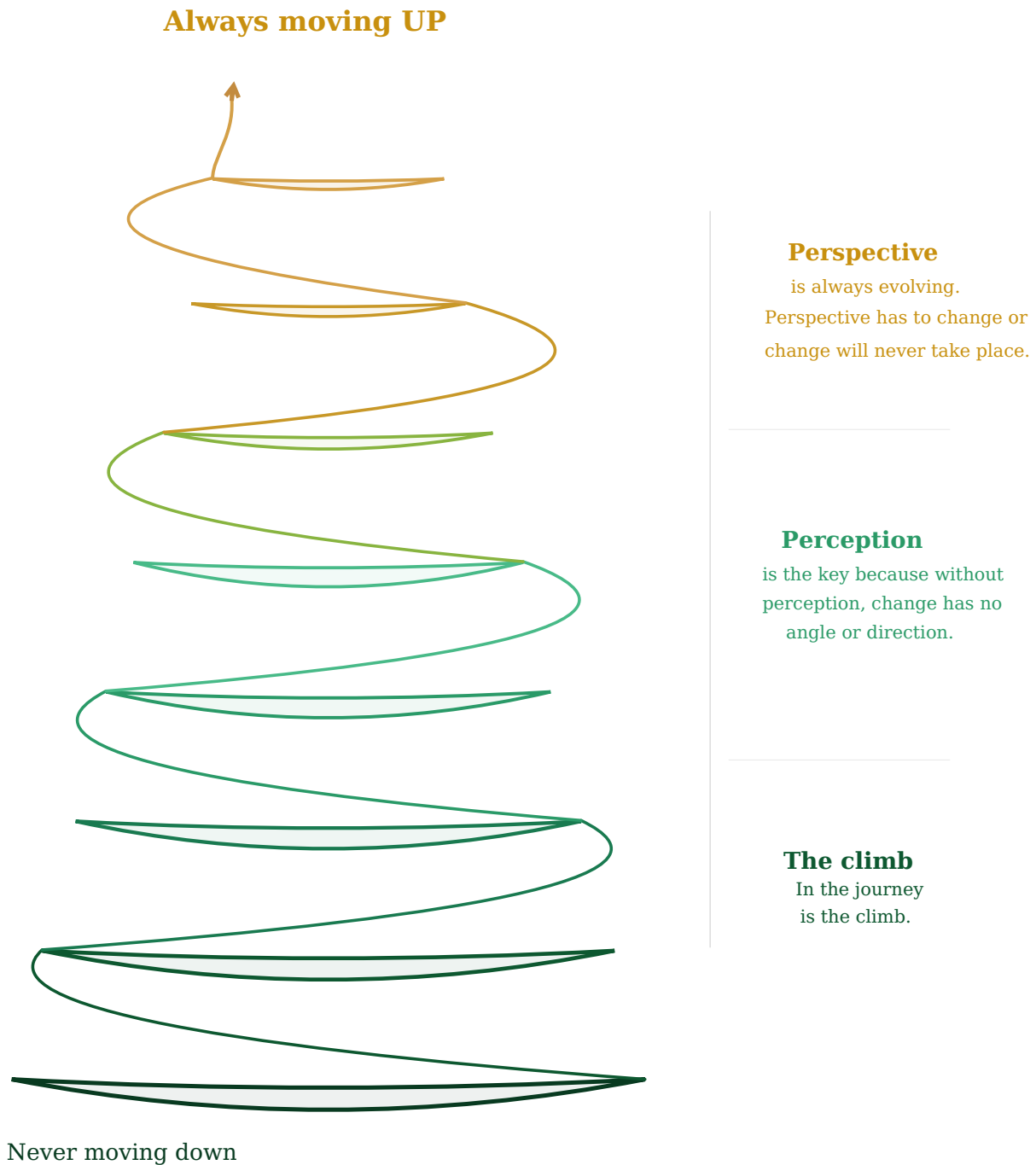


Figure 1. The AOA Framework. Stacked crescents represent levels of ascent. The oscillating pendulum path transitions from deep teal (foundation) to gold (arrival). The arrow at the apex continues the path upward: the path still climbing, beyond the last level into ascension.

The Mechanics: How AOA Works

Every element of the AOA diagram carries meaning. Reading the diagram carefully is reading the framework.

The Crescents: Levels of Ascent

Each crescent represents a level of operation, a plane of the ascent. They are stacked, not sequential. Prior levels remain present, contributing to the foundation of everything above. The widest arc at the base represents the broadest context of transformation. The narrowest at the apex represents its most refined expression.

The Oscillating Path: The Engine of Motion

The pendulum path threads through every level without interruption. Each directional swing carries its own meaning. The left swing: perspective shift, environmental reading, adaptive recalibration. The right swing: integration, forward momentum, application of the new view. The upward vector is the net result of every completed oscillation: always positive, never reversed.

The color transition from deep teal to warm gold is not decorative. It encodes the transformation. The navigator who arrives at the apex is not the same navigator who began at the base. The journey changed them. The color says so.

The Arrow: Terminal Expression

The arrow at the apex continues the path upward: the path still climbing, beyond the last level into ascension. The final pendulum swing does not stop at the last arc. It continues upward and becomes the arrow: a declaration that the ascent has not concluded, only moved beyond the current frame.

What This Combination Produces

A navigator operating within AOA is simultaneously adaptive and directional. They oscillate without losing trajectory. They shift perspective without losing ground. They read their environment without being consumed by it. Adaptability without direction produces drift. Direction without adaptability produces brittleness. AOA produces neither.

AOA in Context

AOA is not the first framework to recognize that change is non-linear. Several established disciplines have approached adjacent territory. What distinguishes AOA is specific, and worth stating directly.

Sinusoidal Progression

Mathematics describes sinusoidal motion as lateral oscillation across a fixed axis. AOA shares the oscillatory structure but departs at a critical point: the axis itself is ascending. The oscillation does not occur around a fixed center. It advances. The wave climbs even as it swings.

Helical Motion

A spring, a coil, a DNA double helix: each moves forward through space while rotating laterally, never reversing its primary direction. AOA's visual model (in Figure 1., p.6) is structurally a flattened helix. The ~~viewed~~ viewed from the side. The rotation expressed as a pendulum path through stacked levels. The physics are the same. The insight is now a navigational framework.

Dialectical Movement

Hegel described the advancement of thought through dialectical tension: thesis, antithesis, synthesis. In his model, tension resolves into a third position that supersedes both. AOA departs here precisely. In AOA, tension propels. The left swing and the right swing do not dissolve into synthesis. They maintain productive friction. The oscillation is sustained, and the sustaining is the ascent. Tension is not the problem. It is the engine.

Adaptive Leadership and VUCA

Contemporary frameworks for volatile, uncertain, complex, and ambiguous environments have moved toward adaptive models, acknowledging that fixed plans fail in dynamic conditions. AOA provides what many of these frameworks lack: a visual and structural account of what adaptive movement actually looks like. Not just that flexibility matters, but the mechanics of how sustained flexibility produces genuine ascent over time.

Applications

The AOA Framework applies across three primary domains. The mechanics remain consistent throughout: the oscillation is not managed away. It is understood, leveraged, and navigated with precision.

Personal Transformation

Individuals navigating career transitions, identity development, or reinvention will recognize the AOA pattern in their own history. The moments that felt like setback: the perspective shifts, the recalibrations, the lateral movements. Through the AOA Framework, those were not deviations from the ascent. They were the ascent. The framework provides language that transforms confusion about one's own trajectory into clarity about actual progress.

Organizational Change

Organizations navigating transformation routinely misdiagnose healthy oscillation as resistance. Organizational leaders intervene to force linear execution and suppress the adaptive intelligence the organization is correctly generating. AOA equips change leaders to distinguish between genuine resistance, which should be addressed, and productive oscillation, which should be protected. The result is more durable transformation with less recovery time from well-intentioned but misplaced interventions.

Leadership Development

Navigators who internalize AOA develop a different relationship with uncertainty. They stop expecting straight lines. They start reading oscillation as data. The lateral movement that once signaled failure now signals active adaptation. They become more effective not because they have more information, but because their understanding of how change moves is more accurate than the understanding held by those around them.

Consulting and Advisory Engagements

For practitioners working in complex environments, AOA provides a diagnostic instrument of genuine value. It allows the practitioner to locate where a client sits within their ascent, identify whether their oscillation is productive or genuinely stuck, and prescribe interventions that work with the natural mechanics of the framework. Clients who understand that their oscillation is expected, navigate transformation with more confidence and less unnecessary turbulence.

Conclusion

The path was never straight. It was always oscillating. And it was always ascending.

The Adaptive Oscillating Ascent Framework does not introduce a new way of moving. It names and illuminates a way of moving that has always been true for those who ascend with authenticity and intelligence.

What AOA adds is precision. The recognition that the left swing is not failure. That the perspective shift is not weakness. That the lateral movement is not a detour. That the climb is fully and completely embedded in the journey, from the first oscillation to the final arc before the arrow points upward into open space.

For those who have felt the frustration of a model that demands straight-line progress in a world that does not cooperate, AOA offers something more than a better framework. It offers a more honest account of what genuine transformation looks like when it is working exactly as it should.

The oscillation is not in the way. The oscillation is the way.

About the Author

Adam McKinski is a senior cybersecurity strategist who has been working at the intersection of security governance, risk, and cloud architecture since 2015. He helps organizations close the gap between security governance and operational reality by translating complex risk into clear, executive-level decisions.

His work spans security governance, risk management, cloud security, identity and access management, and security program maturity across AWS, Azure, and GCP. He has led enterprise-scale initiatives and advised stakeholders across technology, legal, compliance, and audit functions, with a consistent focus on building security programs that are practical, scalable, and aligned to real business needs.

Adam brings to advisory work what the field too rarely delivers: precision over approximation, substance over performance, and outcomes that last beyond the engagement.

A consistent developer of original frameworks, including the 5W Framework and the TRCO Framework, Adam continues to build structured approaches to how security programs think, operate, and transform. The AOA Framework is his most recent contribution: a framework for how transformation actually moves, built on years of watching organizations succeed and fail in the field. He is the founder of CloudSentinel Solutions, where he develops advisory frameworks and thought leadership at the intersection of cybersecurity strategy, cloud architecture, and the organizational dynamics that determine whether security programs deliver lasting value or simply occupy budget.

CloudSentinel Solutions provides enterprise-grade advisory services in cybersecurity governance, cloud architecture, and organizational risk management.